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Crafting Transmedia Worlding

The Power of Reality to Create New Realities

Skriftlig reflektion inom självständigt arbete

Till dokumentationen hör även följande inspelning:

Instructions on How to Survive a War Attack (and still have time for a coffee)

KMH Kungl. Musikhögskolan

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I will never forget this experience.

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Introduction

Over the last two years in the Artistic Interdisciplinary Master (AIM), I have developed a political engagement with my artistic practice, producing a series of pieces that convey my political persona, interests, and socio-political concerns and urgencies. I have investigated different ways of communication with the aim of creating understanding and care about what is happening in our contemporary society.

On some occasions, the response to the work has been conditioned by institutional or committee frameworks, slowing down my process of investigation. These frictions began to shape the inquiry of how it is possible to address historical and contemporary issues in a way that does not confuse the object of critique with the object of representation.

This raises the central question of how artistic practice can critically engage with socio-political realities without reproducing the structures it seeks to critique, and what forms of knowledge such practice can generate.

This text argues that transmedia worldbuilding can function as an ontological and epistemological mechanism in artistic research, enabling critical engagement with socio-political realities while generating knowledge through embodied, performative, and speculative experiences, thus providing a framework to navigate institutional frictions and address socio-political issues without conflating the object of critique with the object of representation. To illustrate this, it draws together the strategies and characteristics that have guided my practice, which cross boundaries between the political, multimedia, and technological domains.

Throughout this paper, I will briefly trace the projects I have been engaged in during this period and how they inform my research. In the second chapter, I will present my project Instructions on How to Survive a War Attack (and Still Have Time for a Coffee) as a case study, highlighting the motivations and creative process that represent the core of this research, as well as its potential for further investigation within artistic research. Finally, my aim is to collectively develop communicative strategies to address the challenges of contemporary society through transmedia art, specifically through the creation of speculative practices and worldbuilding.

Chapter One:

Tensions and Speculative Practices

In this chapter, I outline the complications and frictions that led me to rethink how to address and present my urgencies and artistic practice. The chapter is divided into three sections. The first examines the frictions emerging from previous projects and the challenges they posed. The second introduces speculative fiction and the concept of worlding as a conceptual and methodological framework for this research. The third presents a selection of speculative transmedia practices within the contemporary music scene that resonate with my investigation and function as critical and analytical references.

Frictions

Past projects and Institutional Constraints

In 2022, I developed a collaborative project with the dancer Mara Merchán, in which I aimed to investigate power dynamics between individuals. Grounded in German Expressionist cinema (The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari, The Man Who Laughs, Nosferatu, Frankenstein) and the idea of human subjugation, I composed an interdisciplinary work in which narrative, music, and dance became entangled, creating a performative dialogue in the form of storytelling.

This project represents a turning point in my practice. For the first time, I felt that I was expressing something in itself, gaining distance from a more abstract and interpretative language. This shift encouraged me to apply to the Artistic Interdisciplinary Master (AIM), where I sought to deepen this practice while redefining the case study of how socio-political issues could be addressed through artistic means**.**

However, this conviction was later challenged by a lack of communicative strategies and by institutional constraints, materialized in the form of disputes, misunderstandings and ultimately, requests for cancelation. This experience made me aware of the frictions that emerge when addressing socio-political issues through artistic practice, and of the difficulty of articulating a critical position without reproducing or reinforcing the very structures it seeks to challenge.

During this period, I engaged with themes such as feminism, genocide, surveillance, and structures of control and domination across different projects, each attempting to address socio-political urgencies through artistic means. However, these works also revealed the limitations of my communicative strategies, reinforcing the need to rethink how such issues could be critically articulated.

These concerns became more urgent in relation to the current geopolitical climate. The increasing normalization of war discourse in the Global North, driven by geopolitical domination, militarization, and the persistence of power structures, produces collective affects of fear, urgency, and obedience. Within this context, the risk of misinterpretation becomes even more pronounced**.**

A key moment that crystallized these tensions occurred in Sweden, where I am currently based. In November of 2024, the population received a government-issued civil defense pamphlet, issued by the Swedish Civil Contingencies Agency, outlining how to act in the event of war: maintaining a week's supply of drinking water (3L per person per day), warm clothing and blankets, non-perishable food and a radio that is not reliant on the main electricity supply. Beyond the initial alarm it provoked, the document revealed a striking dissonance: while presented as a tool for preparedness, it constructs an idealized and unrealistic model of survival. It assumes access to infrastructure, financial stability, and resources that only part of the population can realistically meet, thereby offering a false sense of control over an inherently uncontrollable situation. As Martin Gelin (2024) notes, the document effectively shifts responsibility onto citizens, echoing John F. Kennedy's (1961) inaugural call to "ask not what your country can do for you—ask what you can do for your country."

This contradiction between the promise of preparedness and the reality of vulnerability became a central conceptual trigger in my research. Rather than addressing war as an abstract or distant event, this project shifts the focus towards the bureaucratic, pedagogical, and aesthetic infrastructures through which conflict is normalized, managed, and communicated.

These experiences laid the groundwork for my current investigation into how artistic practice can critically engage with socio-political realities while developing alternative communicative strategies that avoid reproducing the structures they seek to critique.

Critique vs Representation

Emerging from these frictions, I began to investigate methods that enable artistic practice to address the difficulties of contemporary society through critique. This investigation led me to identify a fundamental tension between the object of critique and the object of representation. The artwork can be situated along a spectrum, depending on the artist's intentions, possibilities, and strategies for engaging with a given issue. Both approaches, in my view, are equally valid and capable of generating critical insight.

This duality can be understood in terms of matter (critique) and form (representation), corresponding to two fundamental questions: what is being addressed and how it is articulated.

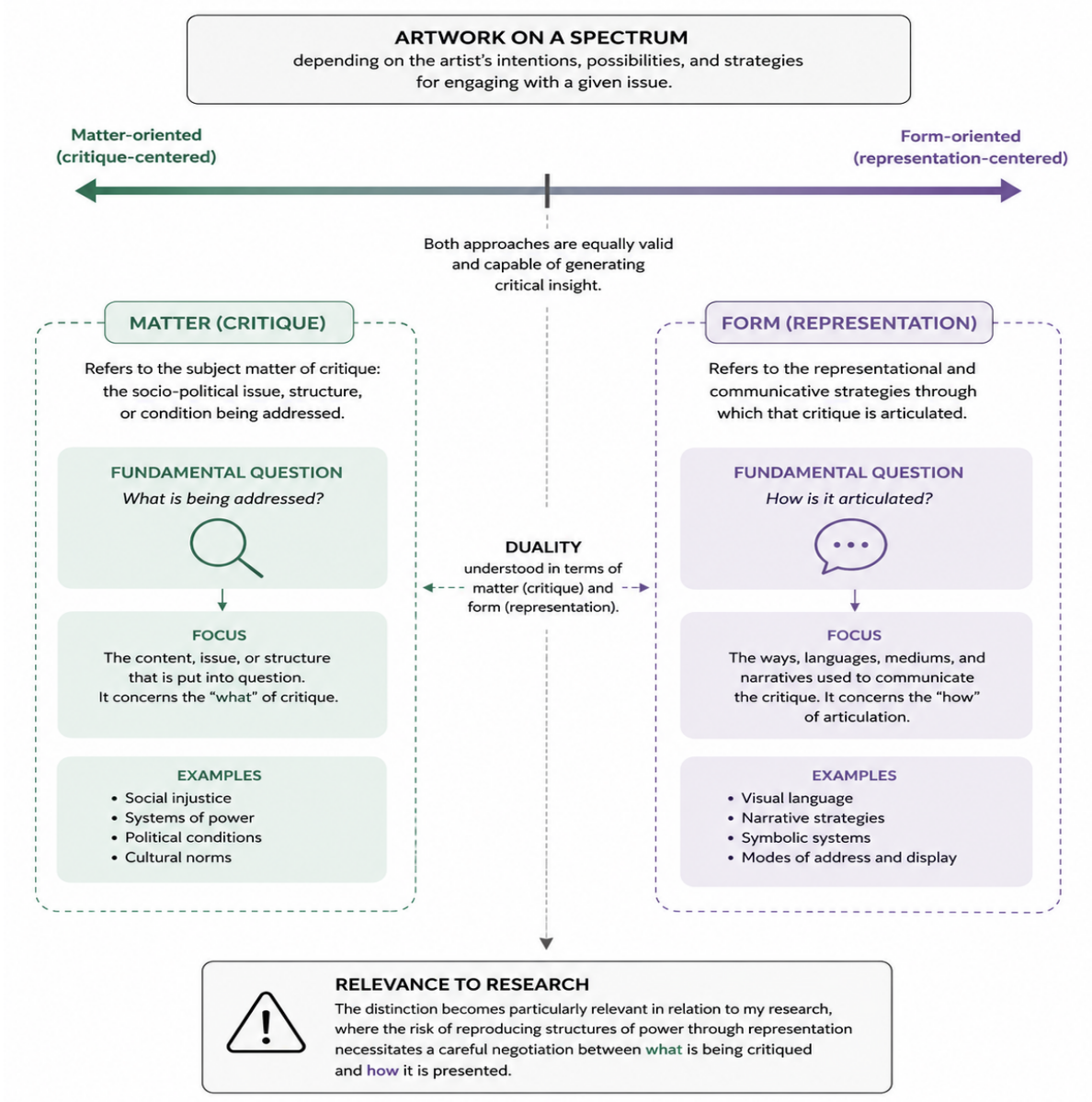


Figure 1: Matter–form diagram spectrum in artistic critique – D.Puerto

Here, matter refers to the subject matter of critique: the socio-political issue, structure, or condition being addressed. Form refers to the representational and communicative strategies through which that critique is articulated. The distinction becomes particularly relevant in relation to my research, where the risk of reproducing structures of power through representation necessitates a careful negotiation between what is being critiqued and how it is presented.

As John of Salisbury recounts, “Bernard of Chartres used to compare us to dwarfs standing on the shoulders of giants. We see more and further than our predecessors, not because our sight is sharper or we are taller, but because their enormous stature lifts us up and holds us high” (Salisbury, 1159). The formulation frames critique as a cumulative and situated practice, in which new perspectives emerge through the rearticulation of existing frameworks.

From this position, I engage with two paintings that inform my approach, demonstrating how different strategies negotiate the tension between critique and representation.

El Guernica – Picasso



Figure 2: El Guernica - P. Picasso

“The attack was fundamentally two things: a terror bombing and an experiment in war” – (Irujo, 2018, as cited in GernikaInfo, n.d.)

Guernica depicts the horror endured by the town of Guernica (Spain), which on 26 April 1937 during the Spanish Civil War, was bombed by the newly created Luftwaffe, German Air Force,

in coordination with The Italian Legionary Aviation and the Condor Legion in support of Francisco Franco's Nationalist faction. Dropping large quantities of bombs on the largely undefended town in one of the conflict's most notorious attacks against civilians, resulting in the destruction of most buildings and hundreds of deaths and injuries among the population (Cecchini, 2025). However, despite the explicit connection to the historical event, the painting is not narrative in a literal sense but symbolic (De la Puente, 1987). The tension generated through Cubist fragmentation functions as a bridge between critique and representation, creating a synergy that reinforces the work's political and ethical content.

¡Lo que puede un sastre!– Goya

"Superstition makes the ignorant public worship a dressed trunk." — Ricart & Helman (1963)



Figure 3: ¡Lo que puede un sastre! - F. Goya

This engraving belongs to Los Caprichos, a series by the Spanish painter Francisco Goya. The image presents a satirical scene in which a crowd, led by a woman, appears to worship a tree trunk covered with a cloth. Through this double reading, Goya constructs a sharp and ironic critique of the blind adoration of idols.

Throughout Los Caprichos, Goya portrays 18th-century Spanish society with irony and biting humor, exposing its violence, moral contradictions, and social vices.

These examples situate my practice within a broader historical lineage in which art operates as a critical and communicative medium. However, rather than merely referencing this tradition, my work emerges from the need to renegotiate these strategies within a contemporary context, where the conditions of communication, mediation, and reception are significantly transformed.

The convergence of this historical framework with my own investigation began to crystallize in 2025 with my project *How Could You Betray Me Like This?,* a collaboration with the

euphonist Marina Boselli for the IDEA Workshop for Young Composers at the Fabbrica del Vapore in Milan.

A multimedia piece for euphonium, mixed electronics and video centred on the figure of Gisèle Pelicot, a French woman who became a feminist icon in 2024 after waiving her right to anonymity as the victim in a multiple rape case involving chemical submission, orchestrated by her ex-husband and involving more than fifty men (BBC, 2024). Her public testimony exposed the persistence of systemic gender-based violence in contemporary society.

The piece traces a trajectory from the abstract, drawing on mythological representations of rape in Ancient Greek narratives, to the figurative, incorporating testimonies from Gisèle Pelicot. This work marked a shift in my artistic practice towards a more conscious engagement with the tensions between critique and representation.



Figure 4: How Could You Betray Me Like This? - D. Puerto

However, while this line of inquiry allowed me to refine my formal strategies, it also revealed a deeper question regarding the persistence of the very structures being addressed. This shift from representation towards underlying systems became central to the following stage of the research, which focused on how narratives and mechanisms of power sustain and reproduce these dynamics.

Power: Mechanisms and narratives

Issues such as systemic gender violence, famine, and war are widely condemned by society. This raises a fundamental question: how is it possible that these injustices persist over time, despite increased access to education and improved social conditions? This question led me to investigate the underlying structures that sustain these dynamics, ultimately converging on the concept of power.

This understanding of power resonates with poststructuralist approaches, particularly Michel Foucault's conception of power as diffuse, productive, and embedded within institutional and discursive structures rather than concentrated exclusively in visible forms of authority.

In this context, power is understood not only as a structural or institutional force, but as a system sustained through narratives and mechanisms that shape perception, behavior, and social organization. Narratives of power construct frameworks of meaning that shape, maintain, and legitimize authority, while mechanisms of power function through institutional, technological, and affective processes that reinforce and reproduce these structures through coercion, ideology, bureaucracy, and surveillance. Accordingly, communicative, bureaucratic, and mediatic systems are not treated as a separate layer of analysis, but as the primary operational modes through which power is enacted and reproduced.

This question informed the development of *BIOLens*, a multimedia project premiered at Limina Festival 2025 in Salzburg, that examines how large-scale systems of violence are



Figure 5: BIOLens - D.Puerto

constructed, mediated, and perceived. The work is grounded in the actions carried out by the Global North against the Global South, focusing on how innocent civilian populations—children, the elderly, and other non-combatants—are systematically positioned as collateral victims in wars, famines, and genocides.

To address this, I collected visual archival material and constructed connections between atrocities of the past century and those we continue to witness today. The piece works as a threshold of violence, increasing the sonic and visual tension, creating a progression from low to high explicitness.

Through this project, my research further developed towards understanding how these narratives and mechanisms operate to legitimize and reproduce themselves, shaping perception, discourse, and collective behavior in ways that often obscure or normalize injustice.

Questions regarding the mediation of violence, the circulation of images, and the normalization of power have been extensively discussed across fields such as media theory, political philosophy, and cultural studies. Rather than attempting a comprehensive engagement with these debates, this project approaches them through artistic practice and compositional experimentation. Questions regarding the mediation of violence, the circulation of images, and the normalization of power have been extensively discussed across fields such as media theory, political philosophy, and cultural studies. Rather than attempting a comprehensive engagement with these debates, this project approaches them through artistic practice and compositional experimentation. The ways in which violence is mediated, normalized, and rendered socially

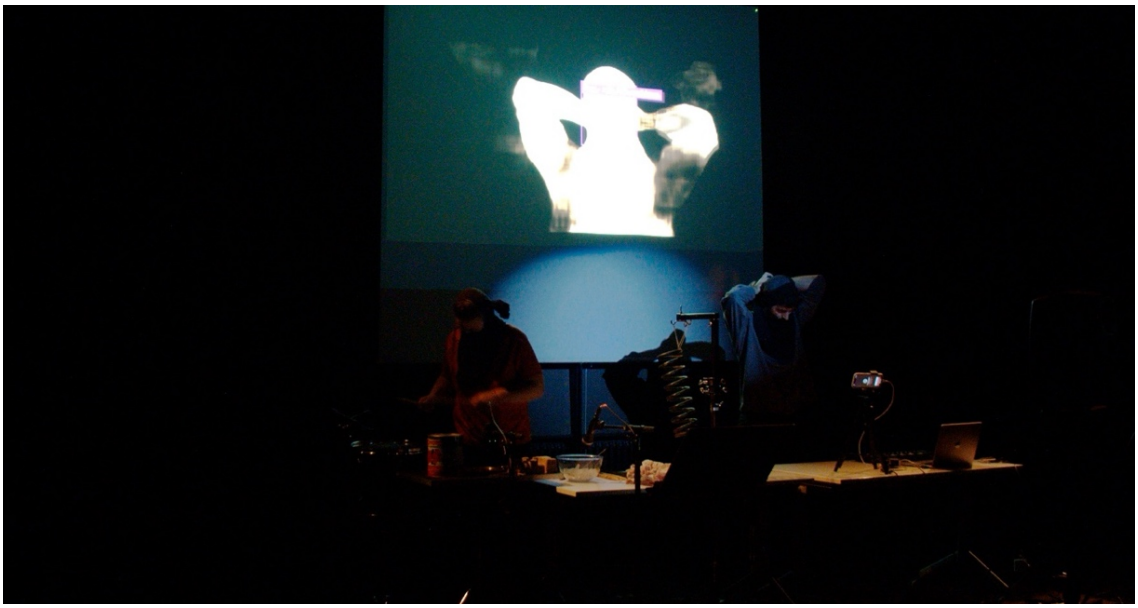


Figure 6: All Cameras Are Cops- D.Puerto

intelligible became central to my artistic research, shaping my interest in how such mechanisms can be exposed, distorted, or destabilized through speculative and performative strategies.

This line of research is reflected in *All Cameras Are Cops*, in which I investigate contemporary surveillance and facial recognition technology in mass protest in collaboration with the percussionist Micaela Belusi, the writer Darren Loucaides, and the media platform *Rest of the World*[1].

ACAC is a multimedia performance that interrogates the use of contemporary surveillance and mechanisms of repression. Through facial recognition technologies and protest objects transformed into instruments, the piece unfolds as a reactive system in which technology and the body confront each other in a choreography of control and resistance.

While these projects allowed me to critically engage with systems of power and develop more defined strategies, they also revealed an important limitation. The explicitness of their content and the clarity of their critical position risked being perceived as moralizing, potentially reducing the work to a didactic or illustrative function.

Rather than enabling critical engagement with the complexity and mediation of these issues, such approaches may unintentionally guide the audience toward predetermined interpretations, thereby limiting the complexity and ambiguity necessary for critical engagement. This tension brought me back to the initial problem identified in this research: how to address socio-political issues without reproducing the structures or modes of communication they seek to critique.

As a result, I began to investigate alternative methodologies capable of displacing this dynamic, moving away from direct representation and towards the construction of experiential and speculative frameworks. Instead of presenting critique as a fixed message, the focus shifted towards creating conditions in which meaning could emerge through interaction, perception, and embodiment. In this context, speculative practices and worlding provided the methodological basis for rethinking the relationship between critique, representation, and communication.

[1] https://restofworld.org/2024/facial-recognition-government-protest-surveillance/

Speculative Fiction and Worlding

Towards Speculative Frameworks

> "Telling stories is a universal human phenomenon that allows for the risk-free exploration of what-if scenarios or hypothetical situations"
> (De Smedt & De Cruz, 2015, p. 2).[2]

Speculative fiction is often understood as a genre—or a subgenre of science fiction—where elements of contemporary society are exaggerated or linked to potential scenarios, allowing us to interrogate the present, question actions, and consider consequences.

De Smedt & De la Cruz quote encapsulates the methodological core I aim to implement in my artistic practice. Although speculative fiction enables hypothetical exploration, the present research departs from the assumption that artistic engagement with socio-political material inevitably produces frictions, risks, and forms of exposure.

As Jade Hinchliffe notes, speculative literary genres are concerned with worldbuilding, utopian and dystopian fictions, all of which carry inherent sociological concerns (Hinchliffe, 2017). Similarly, John A. Weaver frames speculative narratives as reflections of our sensitive reality, providing mechanisms to analyze society and history from multiple perspectives (Weaver, 2018).

However, when speculative scenarios become too detached from recognizable reality, their cathartic potential may be diminished, limiting the audience's capacity for empathy and identification. For this reason, my approach aligns with Donna Haraway's notion of staying with the trouble, emphasizing engagement with the urgencies of the present while tracing their speculative consequences (Haraway, 2016).

This positioning allows for critical engagement without requiring a direct overlap between the object of critique and its representation, directly addressing the tensions outlined in the previous section. In this sense, the juxtaposition of multiple objects drawn from disparate fields becomes not only an artistic strategy but also a form of practical philosophy (Mackay, Pendrell, & Trafford, 2014).

[2] The authors ground this claim in evolutionary approaches to storytelling, particularly the work of Sugiyama (2011) and Tooby and Cosmides (2001).

Speculative Fiction as a Critical Tool

Beyond its narrative dimension, speculative fiction carries significant epistemological value. According to De Smedt and De Cruz, speculative fiction operates as a cognitive tool that elicits attention and reflection, enabling forms of knowledge production that differ from those of analytic philosophy (De Smedt & De Cruz, 2015). While analytic philosophy structures understanding through logical argumentation, speculative fiction generates experiential and imaginative engagement, allowing audiences to explore complex socio-political realities through situated scenarios.

This process is closely linked to mental prospection, the cognitive ability—associated with hippocampal function—to project oneself into possible futures based on autobiographical experience. Neuroimaging studies have shown that remembering autobiographical events, simulating the future, adopting the perspectives of others, and imagining hypothetical scenarios all rely on overlapping neural mechanisms (Buckner & Carroll, 2007). Speculative fiction activates cognitive processes that are fundamental to how individuals construct meaning, anticipate outcomes, and engage with complex socio-political realities.

Speculative fiction operates across different temporal and methodological registers. It can present detailed projections of the near future, grounded in realism and continuity, while also exploring the imaginative possibilities of distant futures, where more radical transformations occur. Through counterfactual thinking, it disrupts the linear chain of causality, proposing“what if” scenarios that disrupt dominant narratives and open space for alternative interpretations of reality (De Smedt & De Cruz 2015).

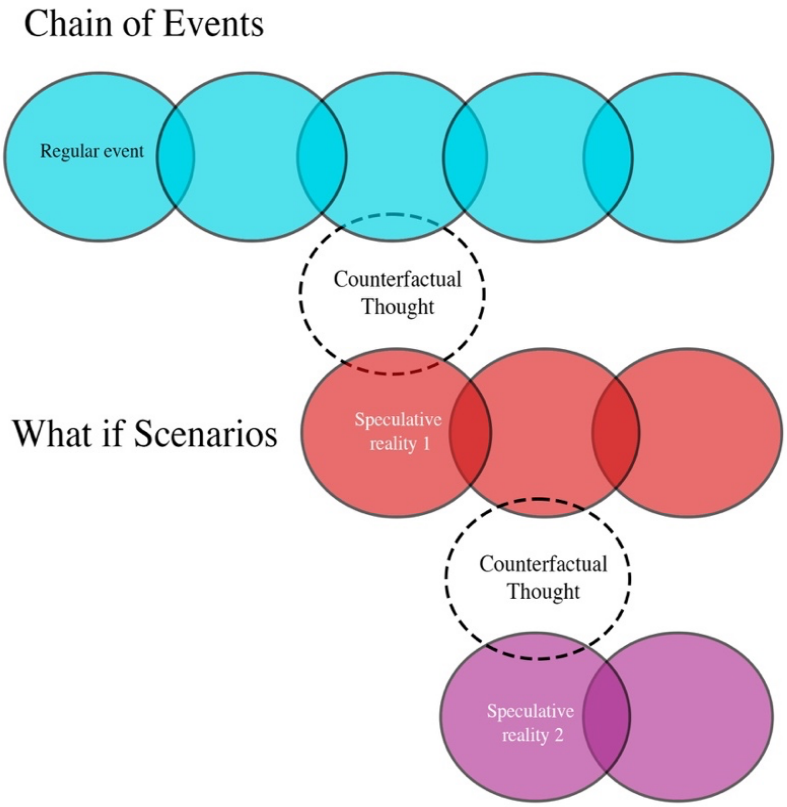


Figure 7: Representation of Counterfactual Thought - D.Puerto

In this context, speculative fiction can be understood as a methodological framework encompassing different modes of practice: as narrative speculation, as artistic methodology, and as a form of speculative realism grounded in material and socio-political concerns. These approaches legitimize speculative fiction as a critical tool capable of addressing contemporary issues—such as power, surveillance, or systemic violence—while avoiding reductive or didactic forms of representation.

While speculative fiction operates primarily at the level of narrative and cognition—generating hypothetical scenarios and enabling critical reflection—worlding extends this process into the material and experiential domain. It is through worlding that speculative thought becomes spatialized, embodied, and perceptible.

By situating critique within speculative frameworks, artistic practice gains the capacity to construct alternative worlds in which existing structures can be exposed, distorted, and reimagined. This capacity becomes central in the transition from speculative thinking to its materialization through transmedia practices and processes of worlding.

Worlding is employed in this research not as a synonym for speculative fiction, but as its material and experiential extension, through which speculative narratives are translated into spatial, embodied, and perceptual conditions.

Crafting Worlding

> "The combination of media that tells a story as the critique
> is established through a synthesis of objects and contextualizing material"
> Malpass (2013, p.348)

Building upon speculative fiction as a methodological and epistemological framework, the concept of worlding emerges as a central strategy for the articulation of critique within artistic practice. Rather than merely constructing fictional environments, worlding can be understood as an ontological and material practice through which alternative realities are configured, experienced, and interrogated. In this sense, it shifts the focus from representation to the reconfiguration of the conditions through which reality is perceived and understood.

Worlding thus operates as the production of conditions through which a world becomes perceptible**,** involving the construction of experiential, affective, and epistemic environments that allow audiences to inhabit and navigate alternative configurations of reality. This approach can be read in relation to Ruth Levitas's concept of utopia as method, which frames worldbuilding not as the design of idealized futures, but as a critical and analytical process that interrogates the assumptions underlying contemporary social and political structures (Levitas, 2013).

This shift from representation to condition directly addresses the tensions previously outlined between the object of critique and the object of representation, enabling critique to emerge through immersion, displacement, and confrontation rather than direct exposition. In continuity with the previously discussed notion of staying with the trouble, worlding operates within existing conditions while simultaneously reconfiguring them.

Within my artistic research, this approach develops through a transmedia worlding framework, in which sound, narrative, visual elements, and performance interact to construct a distributed and multi-layered experiential environment. Meaning emerges through the convergence and friction between these sensory and discursive registers**.**

Within this framework, no single medium assumes a privileged position. All the elements operate as interdependent agents within a transmedia ecology, where meaning emerges through their interaction rather than through hierarchical organization. Sound thus functions not as a central axis, but as a relational force that participates in shaping perception, temporality and embodiment alongside the other media.

The construction of these worlds relies on the juxtaposition, superposition, and collision of heterogeneous elements, including institutional discourse, media narratives, sonic structures, and performative gestures. Rather than producing a coherent or unified narrative, this fragmentation generates a field of tensions in which dominant structures—such as narratives of power, control, and normalization—can be exposed and destabilized.

In this sense, worlding functions as a critical practice that operates through immersion and estrangement. By recreating and distorting the mechanisms through which reality is constructed—such as bureaucratic language, pedagogical instruction, or propagandistic rhetoric—the artwork allows audiences to experience these systems from within, revealing their contradictions and internal inconsistencies.

Importantly, this approach shifts the role of artistic practice from representation to intervention. Rather than illustrating socio-political issues, worlding constructs environments in which these issues are enacted, negotiated, and contested. This enables a form of critique that does not rely on direct didacticism but instead activates reflection through experience, ambiguity, and participation.

Transmedia Practice

Transmedia practices provide the operational framework through which speculative worlding is materialized, enabling the distribution of narrative, affect, and meaning across multiple media. In this section I provide a definition, epistemological strategies, structures of perception and relational systems accompanied by brief representative examples in contemporary art.

Definition and Scope in Contemporary Art

"We are not here to serve.
We are not here to succeed.
We are not here to entertain.
We are not here to do it again.
We are here to get people involved. We will need to be brave.
Thank you."
Wajdi Mouawad (as cited in Rau, 2024, p. 34)

Within contemporary artistic practice, transmedia approaches enable works to move beyond the limits of a single medium. Sound, image, text, performance, and technology operate as interconnected elements whose interaction shapes perception and meaning. This approach becomes particularly relevant in politically engaged practices, where complex realities often resist linear or singular forms of representation. By distributing information across different sensory and narrative layers, transmedia systems create conditions for embodied and situated engagement.

I have chosen two examples of contemporary works that informed the development of my own communicative strategies, particularly regarding participation, perception, and the construction of performative environments.

Playground by Pedro González was particularly influential in my understanding of participation, understood as a compositional and dramaturgical force, capable of shaping collective behaviour and affect (González, 2024).

In the work, the audience becomes the central engine through which the piece evolves, progressively adopting competitive dynamics associated with play and childhood. This reading is based on both González's description of the work (2024, p. 1) and my experience as part of the audience during its premiere at the KlexosLab Festival in Plasencia 2023.

Through the structure of the games themselves, the performance constructs a temporary social environment in which the desire to win gradually conditions interaction, attention, and decision-making. A key aspect that informed this project was the way participation shapes affective investment rather than dramaturgical outcome. Through competitive game structures, the work gradually produces forms of identification, desire, and behavioural alignment among participants.

This approach resonated strongly with my interest in how media systems and institutional narratives mobilize collective affect while concealing the mechanisms through which such alignment is produced. Beyond the idea of communicating ideology directly, the work demonstrates how affective investment, competition, and participation themselves can become mechanisms through which individuals internalize and reproduce behavioural structures.

The relationship between gameplay and musical performance further reinforced this understanding. Audience decisions directly affect the actions of the ensemble, creating a performative system in which social interaction continuously reshapes the musical and dramaturgical development of the piece.



Figure 8: Playground - P.González

Specimen nº6: Plastiglomerates by Alicia Reyes was particularly influential in my understanding of transmedia coherence and the relationship between form and content. Structured as a speculative science-fiction performance situated within a fictional laboratory, the work constructs a fully integrated environment in which scenography, lighting, sound, performance, and technology operate under a shared conceptual logic. Particularly significant for my own practice was the work's ability to construct a coherent transmedia environment through the integration of scenography, performance, sound, and technological mediation (Reyes, 2024).

Scientific procedures, exhibition strategies, live cinema techniques, lighting design, and instrumental performance are presented as interconnected elements belonging to the same fictional ecosystem. The work also influenced my understanding of performers as operators within a system rather than traditional characters. Musicians manipulate objects, activate mechanisms, and conduct experiments, functioning simultaneously as performers and technicians. This resonates with my interest in bureaucratic and procedural structures, where authority emerges through protocols, actions, and mediation rather than individual psychology. Another important aspect is the treatment of perception as dramaturgical material.



Figure 9: Plastiglomerates- A.Reyes

Through spotlights, ultraviolet light, magnification, and live camera systems, the piece continuously directs and reframes attention, constructing shifting scales between microscopic detail, material observation, and staged performance. This treatment of perception as a compositional element directly informed my approach to mediated attention and authority in Instructions on How to Survive a War Attack (and Still Have Time for a Coffee).

Chapter Two:

Instructions on how to survive a war attack (and still have time for a coffee)

In this chapter, I examine the central case study of this text, Instructions […], which represents the culmination of a transformative practice initiated two years ago. This section unpacks the different layers that constitute the piece. Although the work remains in progress at the time of writing, the analysis focuses on its underlying structure.

Context and conceptual structure

This project emerges as a response to the political, economic, and ideological tensions that have intensified in the Global North in recent years—driven by geopolitical domination, militarization, and the persistence of power structures. Such dynamics generate collective affects of fear, urgency, and obedience, gradually normalizing the prospect of war as an anticipated or inevitable condition.

I am currently based in Stockholm, Sweden, where in November 2024 the population received a government-issued civil defense pamphlet outlining how to act in the event of war. Beyond the initial alarm it provoked, the document revealed a striking dissonance: while presented as a tool for preparedness, it constructs an idealized and unrealistic model of survival.

This discrepancy produces a false sense of control over an inherently uncontrollable situation. The tension between the promise of preparedness and the reality of vulnerability constitutes the conceptual starting point of the project.

Project Overview

Instructions on How to Survive a War Attack (and Still Have Time for a Coffee) takes war as its object of representation, while directing its critical focus toward the narratives and mechanisms of power that sustain the illusion that the uncontrollable can be managed through protocols, instructions, and institutional language.

Rather than addressing war as an abstract or distant phenomenon, the work interrogates the bureaucratic, pedagogical, and aesthetic infrastructures through which conflict becomes domesticated, administrable, and normalized. These include civil defense rhetoric, propaganda, institutional narration, and the visual and sonic aesthetics of authority.

The project unfolds as a hybrid between performance, multimedia, and, for an extended collaboration, sound installation with participatory dramaturgy. Audience experience is mediated through a puppet figure—a device derived from pedagogical theatre—which delivers survival instructions with calm authority and exaggerated care, while maintaining the illusion that everyday routines, such as making coffee, can be preserved within crisis conditions.

This juxtaposition between familiarity and emergency, comfort and danger, operates as a central dramaturgical strategy. The use of the puppet format further amplifies the infantilizing tone often embedded in institutional communication, exposing its underlying mechanisms through irony and exaggeration.

The work is currently being developed for the 80th edition of Ung Nordisk Musik 2026, where I participate as a Swedish representative composer in a residency programme in collaboration with the ensemble Neko3. Conceived specifically for the ensemble, the project continues to evolve through an ongoing collaborative process initiated in January 2026.

Collaborative process

Since our first contact in January 2026, I have been working closely with the members of Neko3, Kalle Hakosalo and Lorenzo Colombo, through a combination of email exchanges, online meetings, and in-person sessions. Together, we established an ongoing feedback process through which artistic, conceptual, and practical decisions regarding the project were discussed and negotiated collectively. The first in-person collaboration took place during a residency held between 25 and 31 May 2026.

The development of the project began with an exploration of Neko3's artistic practice, technical possibilities, performance approaches, and musical interests. Rather than adapting a pre-existing composition to the ensemble, the aim was to develop a project specifically shaped through the encounter between our respective artistic practices. Initial conversations focused on instrumentation, the conceptual core of the work, and shared musical references. Particularly

influential was *Black Magic*[3], a collaborative project developed by Neko3 and the Norwegian ensemble Only Slime, whose integration of performance, sound, and theatricality resonated strongly with my own interests.

The collaborative approach adopted in this project was also informed by artistic works that challenge conventional composer-performer hierarchies. Particularly influential was *GemDat*[4] by Carmen Kleykens, which proposes forms of collective authorship and distributed decision-making that extend beyond the traditional model in which performers are primarily responsible for the realization of pre-defined material. Carmen's understanding of collaboration frames collaboration as a process of negotiation through which the artistic identity of the work emerges through the interaction of multiple participants.

This perspective resonated strongly with my own interest in collaborative creation and informed the development of a working process in which artistic, dramaturgical, and practical decisions were continuously discussed and revised together with the members of Neko3.

As the project developed, I created a shared online document that functioned as a working diary. This space allowed me to document the evolution of the project on a weekly basis while enabling the ensemble members to follow the process, provide feedback, and contribute their own observations and ideas. The document became an important tool for maintaining continuity between meetings and for supporting a more transparent and collaborative working process.

Throughout the development of the piece, numerous aspects of the project were revised in response to dramaturgical considerations, conceptual concerns, and the practical needs and perspectives of the ensemble. These adjustments strengthened the collaborative dimension of the work, gradually transforming it from an initial proposal into a project specifically shaped for and with Neko3.

The residency week in May marked a particularly intensive phase of development. Through rehearsals, experimentation, prototyping, and collective problem-solving, many of the project's central ideas were tested in practice. This period not only contributed significantly to the musical realization of the work, but also deepened the collaborative relationships on which the

[3] https://youtu.be/lCC1C_G6Ka0?si=be0hvokV9cYGr8ok
[4] https://youtu.be/T9gVSAZV_Is?si=GHWULotkARWl-kcG

project is built. At the time of writing, the piece remains in development, and the collaborative process continues to inform its ongoing evolution.

Design and Compositional system

One of the central challenges of this project is to reframe composition through the logic of bureaucracy[5]. This involves designing the conditions of an open system, structured through modular formats and a cue-based graphical score that suggests rather than dictates action. Instead of prescribing fixed outcomes, the score operates as a system in which performers respond to specific stimuli, such as tone, timing, or contextual cues.

This approach can be understood in relation to Ursula Franklin's distinction between holistic and prescriptive models of production. While certain author-centered compositional traditions align more closely with a holistic model—where a singular figure oversees and determines the work as a unified whole—the system proposed here incorporates procedural and rule-based structures commonly associated with prescriptive models. However, performers retain interpretative agency through real-time decision-making, modular organization, and cue-based interaction.

In this context, compositional agency is distributed across multiple participants, each contributing through specialized roles. Rather than producing a fixed and predetermined outcome, the work develops through the interaction between structure, performers, and context.

Dramaturgical Phase Walkthrough

The dramaturgical structure of Instructions on How to Survive a War Attack (and Still Have Time for a Coffee) is articulated through four main phases — Prologue, Transition, Instructions, and Closure. Each phase establishes a distinct configuration of sonic, visual, and performative elements, progressively developing the central tension in different strategies such as narrative discourse, social musical constructions, timbres, etc.

These phases operate within a linear dramaturgical structure articulated through shifts in tone, density, and internal logic. While the large-scale form follows a sequential progression, their

[5] This compositional approach recontextualises several Weberian characteristics of bureaucracy as structural principles within the work, including rules and regulations, chains of command, and division of labour.

internal organization remains flexible, allowing the work to continuously reconfigure itself throughout performance.

Prologue

The work opens with a presentation and contextualization of its world through a propagandistic video. The authoritative yet friendly tone of the narration—positioned as a representative of bureaucratic systems and, ultimately, power—shapes the spectator's perception, shifting it from critical distance toward a satirical engagement. This ambiguity creates space for the "grey zones" that the piece seeks to expose.

The function of the prologue lies in preparing the spectator for the confusion that will later emerge in the instructional phase. At the same time, it generates a form of fallacious engagement characteristic of political discourse of this nature, encouraging identification with the cause through phrases such as "it's your war too" or "everyone is doing their part."

Transition

The transition fulfills two dramaturgical functions. On the one hand, it provides a moment of release after the informational density of the prologue, allowing a perceptual reset. On the other, it shifts attention away from the visual domain toward a predominantly sonic environment, introducing a new layer of sensory engagement.

This phase also operates as a bridge between contextualization and enactment. While the prologue establishes tone and references, the direction of the work remains unresolved. In the transition, the initial familiarity—constructed through cartoon aesthetics and a playful tone—is progressively dismantled through sonic saturation and increasing intensity.

The brief emergence of the "guide" introduces a new figure whose status remains ambiguous. While its puppet-like qualities evoke childhood and familiarity, its presence begins to destabilize this association, marking the gradual erosion of the initial frame.

Instructions

The Instructions constitute the central phase of the work. Led by the puppet as a pedagogical authority, a sequence of directives is delivered with apparent clarity and care. The tone oscillates between friendliness and authoritarianism, maintaining a surface coherence that progressively deteriorates.

As the instructions unfold, they become increasingly obscure, impractical, and at times openly absurd. What initially appears as a structured and supportive system transforms into a saturation of information, producing a sense of entrapment.

At this point, the initial contract established with the spectator collapses. The familiar and accessible world constructed in the prologue gives way to a closed and self-referential system, resembling a Kafkaesque loop in which instruction no longer leads to action, but to paralysis.

Closure

The final section of the work culminates in a responsorial cartoon-like song based on scat singing, in which performers and audience progressively participate in a collective act of surrender. After the accumulation of instructions, warnings, protocols, and escalating tension that characterizes the preceding sections, the piece shifts towards an intentionally exaggerated and absurd musical language. Instead of offering resolution, this ending pushes the logic of the work to its extreme, exposing the contradictions underlying the promise of preparedness.

The notion of surrender operates on multiple levels. It may be understood as surrender to bureaucracy, to the illusion of control, to the accumulation of institutional instructions, or simply to the absurdity of attempting to manage an uncontrollable situation through procedural thinking. In this sense, the ending functions simultaneously as catharsis and critique.

The dramaturgical conception of this section draws upon a number of references associated with humour, collective participation, and exaggerated theatricality. One important influence is Everybody Wants to Be a Cat from The Aristocats, particularly in its use of playful vocal exchanges and collective musical energy. Another reference is Cab Calloway's Zah Zuh Zah, whose scat-based language informed the development of the responsorial interaction between performers and audience. Finally, Every Sperm Is Sacred from Monty Python's The Meaning of Life served as a model for the combination of collective singing, irony, and ideological exaggeration, demonstrating how musical spectacle can simultaneously entertain and expose the absurdity of the ideas it presents.

By adopting these references, the final section transforms participation into a performative act of complicity, inviting the audience to join a celebration whose underlying logic is increasingly revealed as contradictory and unsustainable.

The final section introduces double bass and voice as new musical materials. Their incorporation contributes to the shift towards a more song-oriented and collective musical language, supporting the participatory and celebratory character of the ending. The decision of double bass evokes musical idioms associated with jazz, cabaret, and popular entertainment, reinforcing the ironic and theatrical atmosphere of the final scene.

Transmedia system

Sound Composition

The sonic component is articulated through a series of microstructures that operate within the broader conceptual framework of the work. Serving as a unifying element throughout the piece, sound provides a shifting palette of textures and narratives that vary according to its dramaturgical function.

In the prologue, the sonic treatment aligns with the historical aesthetic of the audiovisual material. The voice is processed through an aggressively narrowed band-pass filter (508 Hz–3385 Hz), emulating the limited frequency range of early radio transmission. One key reference is the tonal quality of archival recordings, such as Polish radio broadcasts announcing the German invasion, simulated in grain tone, ambient noise, flutter and distortion by OCS-Cassette simulation by Spectral Plugins.

To complement the visual layer, foley techniques are employed in a manner reminiscent of Mickey Mousing, a technique derived from early animation in which sound closely follows and exaggerates physical gestures. This approach not only reinforces synchronization between sound and image, but also introduces a narrative dimension: foley elements contribute to the construction of specific scenarios (for instance, through the enumeration of locations) and function as satirical devices (as in the exaggerated response to the "duck-tator" figure). The final sonic layer in this section consists of a modular score performed by the Neko3 ensemble. The score is organized into two contrasting modules:

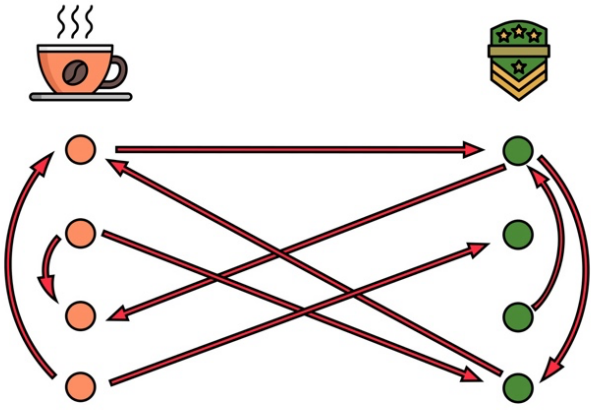


Figure 10: Modular score system – D.Puerto

- Domestic, characterized by soft, jazz-influenced percussion evoking the aesthetics of domestic background music.
- Military, drawing on idioms from ceremonial and military repertoire, such as the Swedish Revelj or The British Grenadiers.

Performers navigate these modules in response to the unfolding textual material, transitioning between them or combining them freely. This system introduces a degree of interpretative agency, allowing the musical layer to dynamically reinforce, contrast, or destabilize the discursive content.
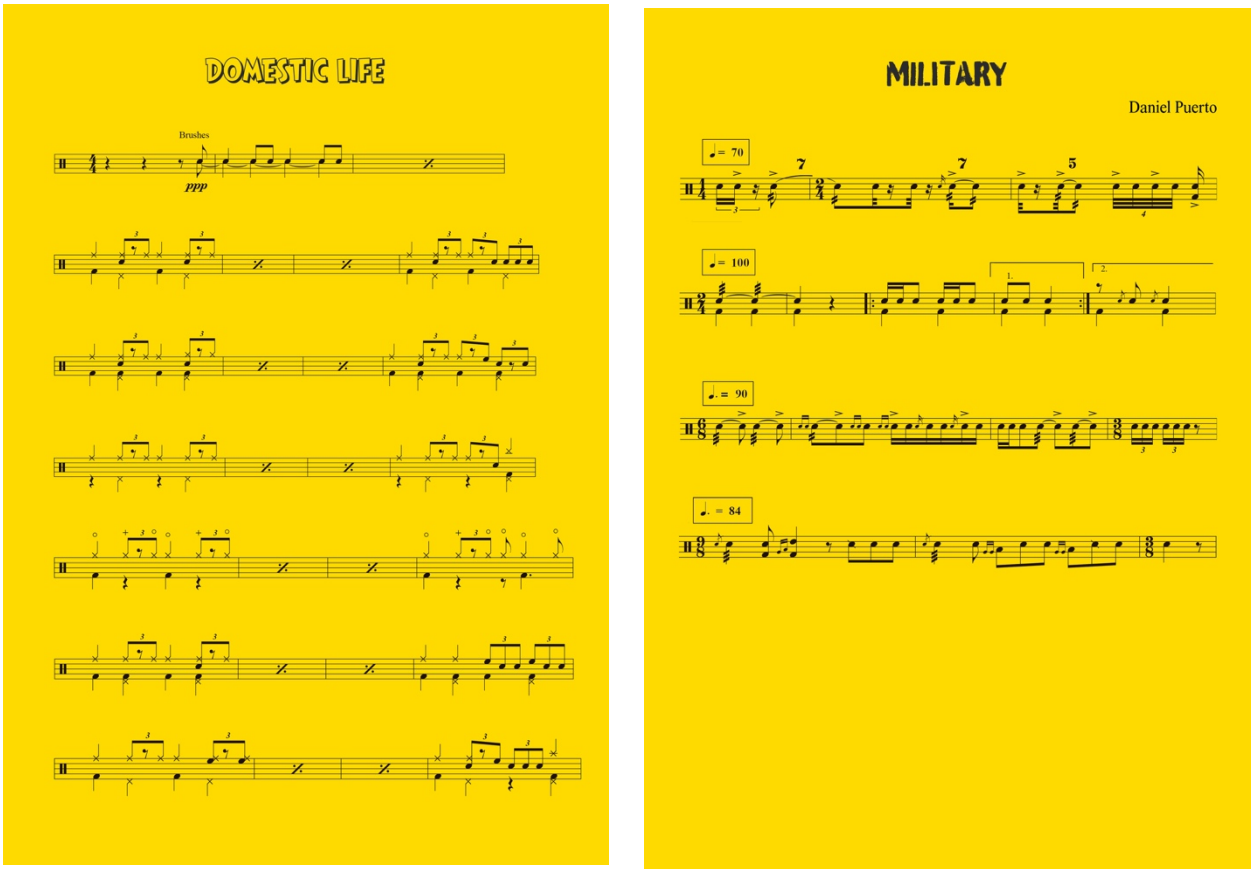


Figure 11: Score Prologue - D.Puerto

After the prologue, a transition section follows, dominated by sound and structured through cue-based improvisation guided by a graphic score. In this section, sound is treated primarily as timbral material through a principle of domesticity, drawing on field recordings of kitchen environments captured with a Sony PCM-D100. These sounds, introduced previously in the prologue as a foreshadowing of the following section, are reconfigured within the SPD-SX PRO played by Lorenzo and performed as a drum kit: microwave door impacts function as kick

drums, spoons striking different surfaces as cymbals, and closing drawers as low-frequency, bass-like events.

The second SPD-SX PRO, operated by Kalle, is based on vocal material derived from the narration presented in the prologue. Using Ableton Live's Simpler device, the samples are distributed across the pads and mapped so that velocity influences pitch, allowing the spoken material to be performed with varying degrees of melodic transformation while retaining traces of its original linguistic character.

The material is organized in Ableton Live into a drum rack distributed across two processing buses operating according to principles of expansion and contraction/distortion. The first bus focuses on spatial and spectral expansion through convolution reverb, delay, granular processing, and echo, increasing sonic complexity. The second bus operates in the opposite direction, applying saturation, FM modulation, and spectral filtering to compress and distort the material.

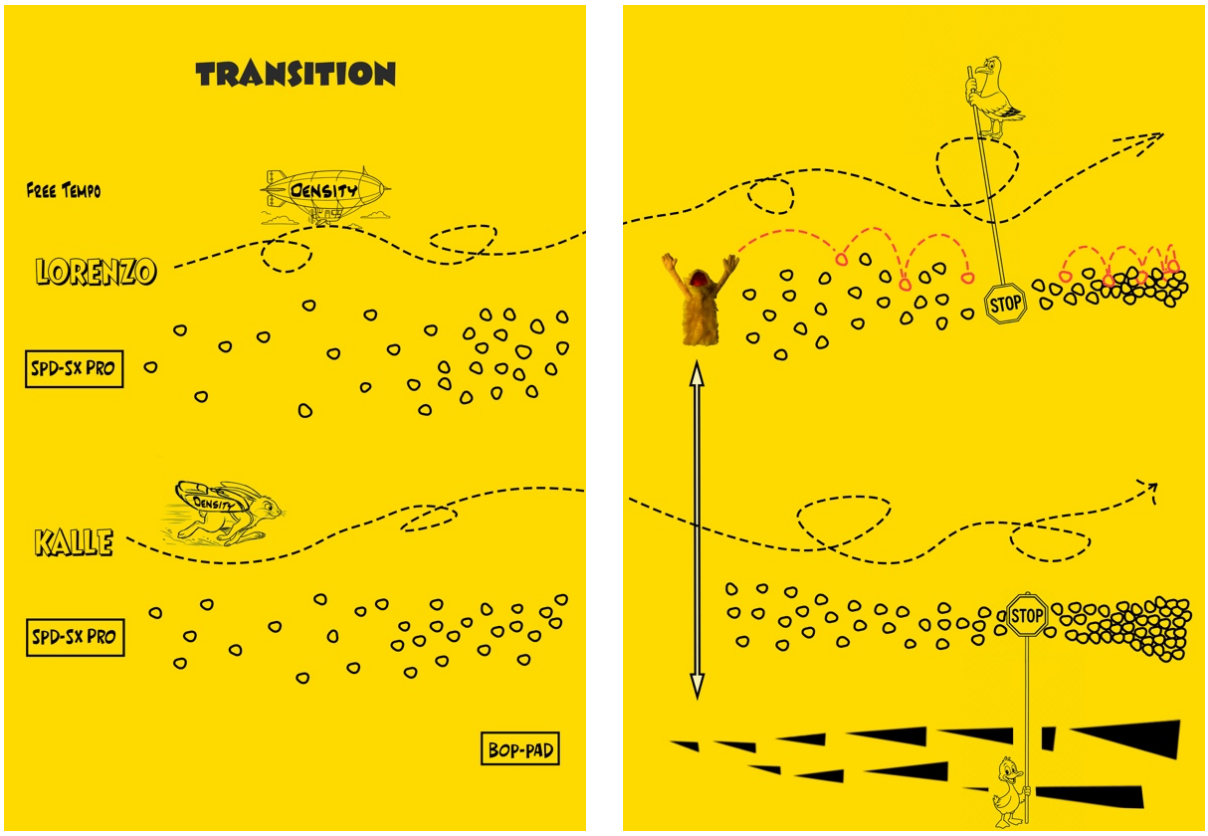


Figure 12: Transition graphic score - D.Puerto

The section lasts approximately four minutes and follows a rapidly accelerating trajectory, structured as an exponential increase in sonic density articulated through the interaction between both buses.

In performance, Bus 1 is driven by velocity-sensitive input from the SPD-SX Pro and processed through a MIDI envelope follower that functions as a density-based control system. Each trigger increases the envelope value proportionally to the temporal proximity of preceding events, so that shorter intervals between hits result in a higher accumulated value. This in turn modulates the wet/dry balance of the processing chain, increasing the wet signal as rhythmic density intensifies. Bus 2, by contrast, follows a fixed envelope structure in Ableton Live.

Additionally, a library of short video fragments mapped to the nine pads of the SPD-SX is triggered via MIDI through Max/MSP, introducing a visual layer that foreshadows the appearance of the instructional "guide" figure. Simultaneously, a dense electronic texture derived from emergency alarm sounds emerges through the BopPad. Stretched using the Paulstretch algorithm and continuously shaped through pressure-sensitive control, this material contributes to the progressive saturation of the audiovisual environment and the growing sense of urgency that characterizes the section. The section is structured through a graphic score which defines its formal boundaries while allowing for real-time interpretative decision-making.

Archive Material

The decision to use archival material to address a contemporary issue is grounded in the understanding of power as a self-perpetuating system. My artistic practice is situated within a historical continuum, while the narratives through which power operates also persist and evolve across time.

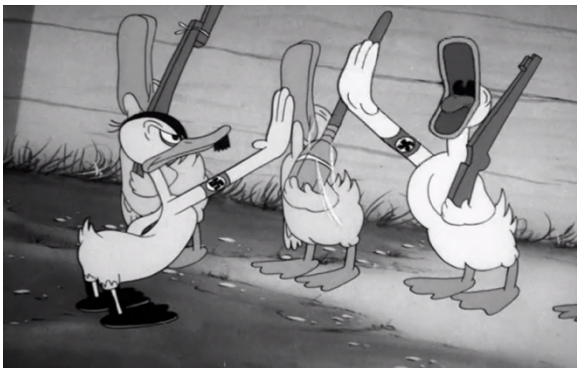


Figure 13: The Ducktator- N. McCabe

By reactivating archival material, the project foregrounds the persistence of these narratives, enabling a critical re-evaluation of historical memory. Rather than treating the archive as a fixed or documentary source, it is approached as an active and malleable structure. This approach constructs a transmedia environment in which fragments from past and present are

brought into relation, exposing recurring political agendas, codes, and mechanisms of authority.

The visual material consists of a curated selection of over one hundred short film excerpts drawn from mid-20th-century animated media, including works produced by studios such as Disney and Warner Bros., as well as individual animators such as Norman McCabe and Max Fleischer. While only a fraction of this material is directly integrated into the final composition, the broader archive plays a crucial role in shaping the aesthetic tone, narrative direction, and rhetorical language of the work.

The selection process prioritizes not only explicit references to war or propaganda, but also recurring formal and tonal strategies—such as exaggeration, moral instruction, and caricature—which reveal how ideological content is embedded within seemingly innocuous or entertaining formats. As a result, the archive operates not simply as a repository of images, but as a field of patterns through which mechanisms of persuasion can be identified and reconfigured.

Multimedia Integration

The integration of audiovisual material is informed by the analysis of specific works such as Wacky Blackout, The Ducktators, Spirit of ’43, and Porky’s Snooze Reel among others, from which tonal strategies, humor structures, and rhetorical devices are extracted and recontextualized.

A key challenge in the selection process was that only a limited portion of the available material directly addressed war or propaganda. This constraint prompted a shift away from literal representation towards a more abstract and associative relationship between text and image.

As a result, the visual composition is structured as a rapid montage of short clips, approximately three seconds in duration, organized to alternately reinforce or contradict the spoken text in the prologue. This interplay generates a dynamic of correspondence and dissonance, in which meaning emerges not from alignment, but from tension.

This strategy extends beyond formal experimentation and operates as a critical mechanism: by disrupting the coherence between image and discourse, the work exposes the instability and constructed nature of institutional narratives. In doing so, it aligns with the broader

methodological logic of the project, in which fragmentation, juxtaposition, and contradiction function as tools for destabilizing dominant structures of meaning.

This logic of fragmentation and dissonance extends beyond the visual domain and becomes central to the performative structure of the work. Throughout the piece, this core idea reappears in the Instructions section, where the puppet emerges as a form of institutional authority. As the instructions unfold, discursive tension gradually increases through the accumulation of absurdity.

Aesthetic and Narrative Strategies for Worlding

The construction of this world is grounded in an analysis of bureaucracy as a mechanism of power, as well as war and satire understood across historical and contemporary contexts. These systems establish a conceptual base that informs the development of tone, references, and narrative strategies.

The plurality of stimuli shapes audience attention by distributing focus across multiple layers of the work, with certain elements becoming temporarily foregrounded while others recede. The use of satire as a communicative medium introduces a specific tension: its critical sharpness risks rejection or misreading, particularly when its tone becomes too abrasive. This tension generates a negotiation between form and content, where the instability between message and mode of address becomes structurally productive. Moments of relief or partial catharsis are carefully calibrated, as they can also weaken the tension that sustains the work's critical strategy.

These decisions form a continuous negotiation between conceptual intent, perceptual organisation, and communicative effect, through which the world is progressively constructed.

Analysis and Discussion

The core of this work resides in contradiction, operating simultaneously as a structural principle, a discursive strategy, and a performative condition. This contradiction emerges from the tension between two implicit contracts: on the one hand, the institutional promise of safety and preparedness; on the other, the underlying instability and uncontrollability of war.

This dynamic can be understood through the concept of ludonarrative dissonance, a term coined by Clint Hocking (2007) to describe the conflict between a game's narrative framework and its gameplay mechanics. In his analysis of BioShock, Hocking identifies a tension between the ideological premise of individual agency—grounded in Objectivist philosophy—and the player's enforced dependence on the character Atlas to progress. This contradiction produces a rupture between what the game asserts and what it requires the player to do.

A similar logic operates within this project. The work stages a dissonance between the instructions it provides and the conditions under which they unfold. While the discourse presents an image of control, clarity, and preparedness, the performative environment gradually reveals the absurdity and impracticability of these directives.

By adopting this structure, the project mobilizes contradiction as a critical device. The work constructs a system in which compliance becomes increasingly untenable as its internal logic unfolds. Therefore, ludonarrative dissonance is enacted, functioning as a meta-narrative strategy that exposes the bureaucratic logic it seeks to interrogate.

As such, contradiction operates as a generative principle through which the work produces critical insight.

Addressing Frictions Through Artistic Practice

This project approaches artistic practice as a site of negotiation rather than representation, where frictions are not resolved but operationalized. These frictions emerge from the gap between critical intention and communicative reception, particularly when engaging with socio-political material within institutional frameworks. This notion of negotiation does not imply equivalence between positions. It refers instead to the operational space in which asymmetries, power relations and ethical tensions are made perceptible.

It does not attempt to eliminate that tension, rather, the work treats it as a productive condition that informs both methodology and form. Artistic practice operates as a mode of interference: a way of introducing instability into established systems of meaning, without reverting to didactic articulation or moral positioning.

Therefore, critique is embedded in its operational logic. Meaning emerges through the friction between systems—between instruction and execution, authority and ambiguity, structure and failure—allowing the work to function as a critical environment rather than a fixed statement.

Ontology and Epistemology: Knowledge Generated Through Practice

In this research, knowledge emerges through practice itself. Artistic production is therefore positioned as an epistemic process grounded in enactment, iteration, and embodied engagement.

The transmedia nature of the work reinforces this condition by distributing knowledge production across multiple registers—sonic, visual, performative, and dramaturgical—none of which function as illustrative of a central idea. Instead, meaning is produced through their interaction and mutual disruption.

From this perspective, ontology and epistemology are not separate domains: the "world" constructed by the work and the knowledge it generates are co-constitutive. What exists within the piece is inseparable from how it is perceived, navigated, and performed. Knowledge therefore arises as a situated and temporal event, rather than a stable or transferable conclusion.

Conclusions

This research has examined transmedia worlding as an artistic and methodological framework for constructing relational systems in which meaning emerges through the interaction between media, perception, and dramaturgy. Across the projects and case studies discussed throughout the text, composition is approached through the organization of conditions capable of constructing worlds, behaviours, and modes of attention.

Transmedia practice is therefore understood as an operational logic that articulates complex socio-political tensions through layered and interdependent structures. From this perspective, contradiction, fragmentation, mediation, and perceptual negotiation function simultaneously as aesthetic strategies and epistemic tools through which artistic practice generates situated forms of knowledge.

The development and analysis of Instructions on How to Survive a War Attack (and Still Have Time for a Coffee) allowed these concerns to converge within a compositional system grounded in bureaucracy, satire, and institutional language. Through the interaction between sound, archival material, graphic notation, performance, and audiovisual montage, the project explores how transmedia environments can mobilize affect, destabilize systems of authority, and expose the frictions between control, instruction, and lived experience.

At the same time, the thesis understands these investigations as part of an ongoing process. While the present analysis focuses on the short-format version developed for its premiere context, the project remains conceived as an expandable system. In ongoing collaboration with the ensemble Neko3, future iterations aim to extend the work into longer multi-channel formats incorporating spatialization and audience participation.

The research ultimately positions transmedia worlding as an evolving field of artistic inquiry with potential for further development within future doctoral research focused on artistic practice, epistemic production, and relational systems.

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Glosary

Ludonarrative Dissonance: Conflict between the actions encouraged by a system and the narrative or ideological message it communicates. Within this research, the concept is employed to analyse situations in which participatory structures expose contradictions between institutional discourse and lived experience.

Speculative Fiction: Methodological and artistic strategy through which alternative realities can be imagined and explored. Rather than predicting the future, it functions as a critical tool that makes visible the assumptions, contradictions, and power structures embedded within the present.

Worlding: Process of constructing the material, perceptual, and experiential conditions through which a world becomes inhabitable and intelligible. In this thesis, worlding is understood as the practical extension of speculative fiction, translating fictional premises into environments, systems, and situations that can be experienced, navigated, and critically examined.

Narratives of Power: Systems of representation and meaning that legitimize, justify, and sustain authority. They shape how social realities are interpreted and understood, often naturalizing existing power relations through stories, symbols, ideologies, and forms of communication.

Mechanisms of Power: Institutional, technological, bureaucratic, communicative, and affective processes through which authority is exercised, maintained, and reproduced. Unlike narratives of power, which operate through meaning and representation, mechanisms of power operate through procedures, infrastructures, and systems of organization.

Participation: Active involvement of audiences or performers in the development of a work. In this thesis, participation is understood not merely as interaction, but as a compositional and dramaturgical force capable of shaping meaning, behaviour, and collective experience.

Agency: Capacity of participants to make decisions and influence the unfolding of a situation. Within this research, agency is understood as distributed across performers, audience members, technological systems, and compositional structures, rather than residing exclusively in a single authorial figure.

Distributed Compositional Agency: Mode of artistic production in which decision-making is shared among multiple participants. In this thesis, compositional outcomes emerge through the interaction between performers, technological systems, dramaturgical structures, and contextual conditions rather than being fully determined by a single author

Transmedia: Construction of a coherent artistic world through multiple media forms operating across different modes of representation. Within this research, transmedia practices are understood as a means of reinforcing dramaturgical coherence and expanding the experiential dimensions of worlding.

Dramaturgy: Organization of actions, events, tensions, and relationships that shape the audience's experience of a work. In this research, dramaturgy extends beyond narrative structure to include participation, media interactions, sonic developments, and systems of communication.

Preparedness: Promise that uncertainty, crisis, or catastrophe can be managed through planning, protocols, and institutional guidance. The concept is examined critically throughout the research as a narrative that may generate a sense of security while simultaneously obscuring the limits of control.

Complicity: Process through which participants become implicated in the logics, behaviours, or systems presented by a work. Rather than positioning audiences as external observers, the projects discussed in this research often invite participation that reveals how individuals may unknowingly reproduce the structures they are encouraged to question.